



▲ Riding high

The idea of witches riding goats, a symbol of lustful devilry, was a common one. In this image by Albrecht Dürer from the early 1500s, the goat is ridden backward, representing a reversal of the natural order.

“A ‘witch’ is one who knowingly tries to accomplish something through diabolical means.”

JEAN BODIN, *DE LA DEMONOMANIE DES SORCIERS*, 1580s

Agents of the Devil

Renaissance clerics and philosophers often depicted witches as working with demons and the Devil; many produced detailed guides on the nature of witches and how they interacted with demons. Opinions varied: according to some, demons had to be controlled by witches, while for others, demons might well be witches’ helpers.

For influential English Puritan cleric William

Perkins, being in league with the Devil was part of what defined a witch. To him there was no such thing as a “good” witch, as all witches consorted with the Devil. His key work, *Discourse of the Damned Art of Witchcraft* (1608), did much to introduce such European ideas to England and North America.

Demonic influence

Many books detailed sorcery involving demons, and their authors often used the word *maleficium* to describe malevolent magic. Titles included *Malleus Maleficarum* (1484), by German churchman Heinrich Kramer, and *Compendium maleficarum* (1608), by Italian priest Francesco Maria Guazzo. Both texts contributed to the hounding of witches (see pp.178–181), as did the work of Jean Bodin, who believed in demons, stood hard against sorcery, and took part in persecutions. Dutch physician Johann Weyer in *De praestigiis daemonum* (1563) took

an anti-persecution stance, however, that opposed conventional anti-witchcraft dogma. He thought witchery arose from delusion or mental instability.

Coming of the modern witch

The modern European concept of the witch as a woman involved with demons was cemented in the Renaissance, and the majority of witch trials were directed at women. Poor, often single, women were vulnerable to accusations from neighbors seeking supernatural explanations for misfortune. Women were also deemed more susceptible to devilry; Perkins’s *Discourse* stated: “the woman, being the weaker sex, is sooner entangled by the Devil’s illusions ... than the man.” Such ideas persisted for centuries, as did the image of the “wicked witch.”

► Witches’ sabbats

Flemish artist Frans Francken II’s *Witches’ Sabbath*, 1606, shows a nighttime sabbat (gathering) of witches. Sensational tales circulated of sabbats involving thousands of witches.



► Brewing trouble

This Renaissance-era German woodcut shows two witches cooking up a spell with a snake and a chicken. Witches using fires and cauldrons became stock images during this period.